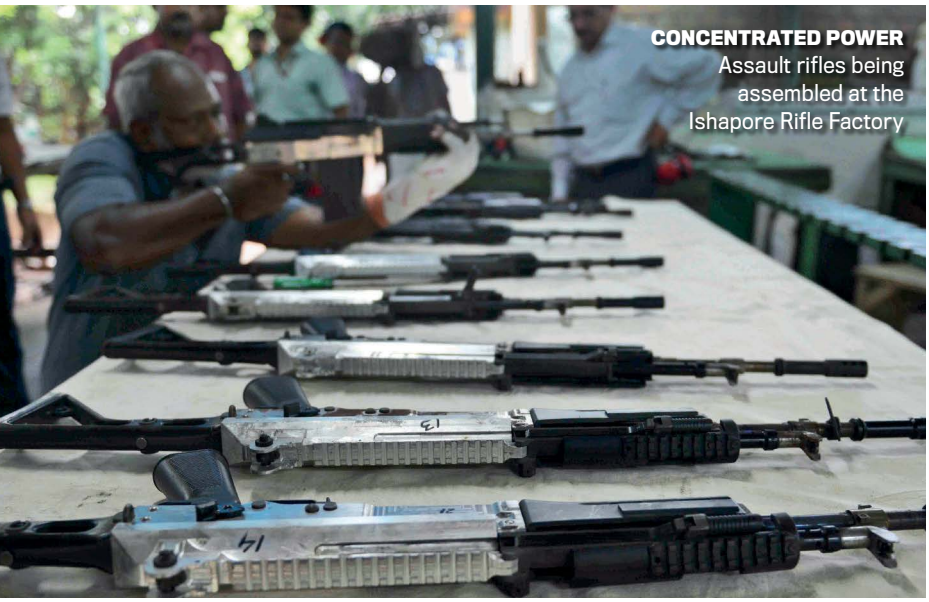


CONCENTRATED POWER Assault rifles being assembled at the Ishapore Rifle Factory

SUBIR HALDER

RPL) was set up in 2019 as a joint venture between OFB (with a 50.5 per cent majority stake), Kalashnikov (42 per cent) and Russia's state-owned defence export agency Rosoboronexport (7.5 per cent), under which the rifles would be manufactured at the Korwa Ordnance Factory in Amethi, Uttar Pradesh. The IRRPL planned to import 800,000 AK-203s for around $1,100 (Rs 81,000) apiece to meet the army's urgent operational needs, followed by the licensed production of the remaining 650,000 units.

Lt Col. Manoj K. Channan, who has been part of multiple Make in India projects, says financial constraints and the issue of indigenous components posed a significant hurdle in the AK-203 project. "The high costs associated with the royalty and transfer of technology rendered the project financially untenable, especially compared to alternative weapons available to the armed forces," says Lt Col. Channan. The current pricing model indicates that India could acquire three foreign-made rifles for the cost of one domestically-produced AK-203, he adds.

To tide over its immediate needs, the Indian military in 2019 acquired 72,400 US-made Sig Sauer 7.62 x 51 mm rifles. The Sig Sauer, one of the best weapons in its class, was chosen for its ruggedness, complete reliability and a long range of 600 metres. It has higher accuracy than the AK-47 and INSAS. Indigenised with local night vision systems, grips, bipods and India-made ammunition rounds, this American weapon is now a formidable weapon in the hands of Indian soldiers patrolling the borders with China and Pakistan. From the lot, the army got the major share of 66,400 rifles, the Indian Air Force received 4,000 and the Navy got 2,000. Soon after, the MoD restricted the import of assault rifles by adding them to the Positive Indigenisation List of weapon systems. However, last December, the army convinced the ministry of its urgent requirement for another tranche of 72,000 units of Sig Sauers. "We would not have gone for imports if locally made rifles were meeting our basic requirement. We are left with no option but to import," says a key army official.

The advent of the Sig Sauers aren't the end of the road for INSAS rifles. Considering their large-scale use, military planners have worked out a plan to upgrade the existing inventory of INSAS rifles, deeming this an operationally viable and cost-effective solution. While some paramilitary forces and state police have started using the upgraded INSAS, the northern command of the Indian Army proposes to do the same.

Samir Dhawan, director of Star Aerospace, which has offered an upgrade of the existing INSAS rifles, claims his company has provided the upgraded rifles to the paramilitary and state police forces. He adds that the optimally modified INSAS rifle offers state-of-the-art characteristics and contemporary features.

The latest indigenous rifle on offer—but untested as yet—is the 7.62 mm caliber Ugram, jointly developed by the Armament Research and Development Establishment of the DRDO and the Hyderabad-based private firm Dvipa Armour India Private Limited.

The perennial hunt for an assault rifle to arm the world's second-largest standing army is not ideal. A complex inventory of different assault rifles can create confusion in times of conflict too. While expediting ongoing projects, the private sector's involvement is a must for a permanent Make in India solution towards a single, stable weapon. ■



"INDIA DOES NOT HAVE AN INDIGENOUS ASSAULT RIFLE DUE TO THE THE INABILITY TO CLEARLY DEFINE NEEDS, AND THE FAILURE OF PUBLIC SECTOR RIFLE FACTORIES"

LT GEN. ANIL AHUJA (RETD)
Former Deputy Chief, Integrated Defence Staff